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18. Started a clothing brand at 16 with no money, grew it to \$1.29M in sales in 16 months with no outside funding, and taught myself to write the software I run it on. Finished high school in June 2026 and chose to build full time instead of going straight to college.

experience

Founder, v2byVELARE (Velare LLC)

June 2025 – Present

- \$1.29M in Shopify sales and 14,700+ orders since launch, no outside funding. \$138K in the first full month, best month \$213K and 2,500+ orders (Dec 2025)
- Run every part of the business: product design, overseas manufacturing (\$240K+ in production in 2026), ads, SMS, fulfillment, cash, and a 3 person contract team
- Built an 89K follower Instagram and 16K person SMS list, mostly organic, and use them to launch limited drops. Best single day \$45K (May 2026)
- Directed \$195K+ in Meta ad spend with an outside agency, set budgets and break-even targets, held around 5x revenue per ad dollar in scale months
- Used sales data to cut the catalog down to proven winners: the original 6 products drove about 60% of all revenue

Founder, VELARE (first brand)

Aug 2024 – July 2025

- Started at 16. First drop sold 2 of 100 units (my mom and a friend). Grew to about \$100K in the first year
- Got through \$30K of inventory stuck in customs, then relaunched as v2byVELARE, which did 6x the monthly revenue

things i built

Self-taught with Python and AI coding tools (Claude Code) since January 2026. 12 projects, 40K+ lines of code.

- **Drop Gate:** real-time waiting line for drop day (Node, Socket.io, Postgres). Load-tested to 2,583 people in line at once with 0 failures on a \$5/month server, 64 automated tests
- **Content analytics engine:** pulls Instagram performance data through the official API on 800+ reels, tags every video, and scores which formats drive reach. Found that reach follows a power law driven by watch time, not the format I assumed
- **Cash Deck:** live dashboard on the Shopify Payments and Balance APIs showing cash across accounts, upcoming bills, and drop scenarios on a weekly simulator. I run the business off it
- **Trading research:** backtesting framework with blind holdout tests, cost modeling, and kill rules written before each test. Tested ~210K ideas; the flagship looked like +\$13K on paper, lost in 5 months of forward testing, and was killed by its own predeclared rule
- **Personal AI system:** a structured knowledge base and agents that plan, research, and track the business overnight

other

- Started Execution Group, a community of 250+ young clothing brand founders that grew out of free guides I wrote on organic marketing. Still active daily without me
- Wrote a full course for new brand founders: 71 videos, about 32K words
- Spoke at NYU Stern (Sep 2025) on using AI in startup marketing
- Paid model and creator for 12+ streetwear brands; organized a group popup during NYFW (Feb 2026)
- Given away \$57K+ in clothing at retail value, about 800 pieces: 250+ to shelters and youth programs, 400 at one giveaway
- Irvington High School, graduated June 2026. Admitted to Northeastern. Varsity soccer 4 years, piano 10 years, fluent Spanish